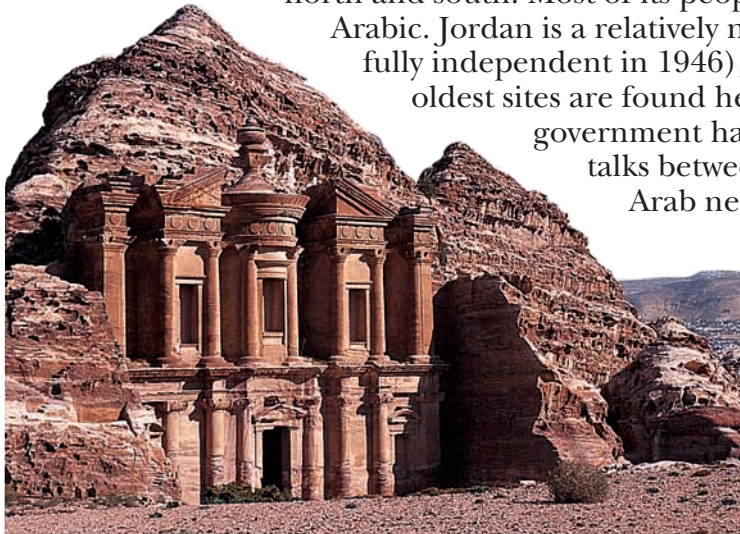


**JORDAN**

Capital city: Amman
Area: 35,637 sq miles (92,300 sq km)
Population: 5,500,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 92%, other 8%
Government: Monarchy with democratic system
Currency: Jordanian dinar
Adult literacy rate: 91%
Life expectancy: 72 years
People per doctor: 588
Televisions: 52 per 1,000 people

JORDAN

JORDAN LIES TO THE NORTHWEST of the Arabian Peninsula. Aside from a short coastline along the Gulf of Aqaba, it is completely landlocked, or cut off from the sea. Much of eastern Jordan is desert, with mountains in the north and south. Most of its people are Muslim and speak Arabic. Jordan is a relatively new country (it became fully independent in 1946), but some of the world's oldest sites are found here. In recent years, the government has played a part in peace talks between the Israelis and their Arab neighbors.



Ed-Deir (The Monastery) is the largest monument in Petra.

PETRA

The spectacular rose-red city of Petra was carved out of desert rock by the Nabateans in the 4th century BC. It is Jordan's most famous historic site. Among the amazing rock-cut buildings are the Khazneh (Treasury) and the Royal Tombs, reached on horseback through a narrow, winding gully.

REFUGEE CAMPS

When Israel was formed in 1948, tens of thousands of Palestinians were forced to flee their homes and become refugees in Jordan and other Arab countries. More than 40 years later, they are still there. In Jordan alone, there are 1.6 million Palestinian refugees. Many have been born and brought up in refugee camps. This Palestinian refugee camp is near Amman.

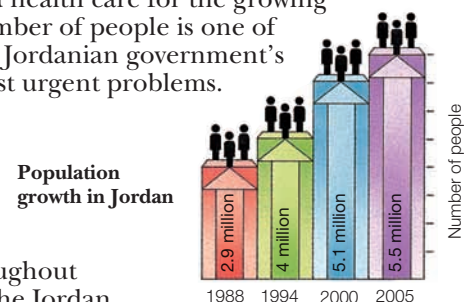


Houses being built in Amman



POPULATION GROWTH

The population of Jordan, roughly equally divided between Jordanians and Palestinians, is growing rapidly. Providing housing, jobs, schools, and health care for the growing number of people is one of the Jordanian government's most urgent problems.

**GULF OF AQABA**

The Gulf of Aqaba is the narrow, northeastern arm of the Red Sea between Saudi Arabia and the Sinai Peninsula. It is 99 miles (160 km) long and up to 17 miles (27 km) wide. At its head lies Jordan's one seaport, Aqaba. This short stretch of coastline is Jordan's only outlet to the sea. It is also popular with vacationers.



JORDAN RIVER

Water is in short supply throughout the Middle East. Control of the Jordan River, which forms the border between Jordan and Israel, has become an important issue in peace talks between the two countries. Jordan, a relatively poor country, has a particular need for a greater share of the water to irrigate its land so it can produce more crops.

Find out more

ANCIENT SITES: 134

ISLAM: 275

MIDDLE EAST HISTORY: 146–147

POPULATION GROWTH: 16–17